Munna Bhai had popularized a pop icon Mahatma, a quaint throwback to the nostalgia-laden black-and-white era. Anna was clever enough to project himself as this New Age Mahatma, ideally suited for an urban public looking for a shortcut to reliving the heady atmosphere of the freedom struggle.

OB vans had now been permanently parked at the site. Live shows were being done from the venue by senior TV anchors, angry voices being magnified by the TV echo chamber in the studio. Just as Gandhi mugs and keychains had done good business after the *Munna Bhai* movie, now ‘Anna caps’ and tricolours were being sold at the venue like fairground delights. Candlelight marches were organized at India Gate and across several state capitals, while the social media buzzed with the Anna refrain through Facebook posts and Twitter trends.

In hindsight, it’s easy to suggest we overplayed the Anna protests. A television anchor likened it to the ‘second war of independence’, while one channel created a permanent screen slug ‘Anna is India’. News television has a tabloidish urge that thrives on conflict and controversy. The outrage at times is deliberately manufactured and I cannot claim to be indifferent to the temptation to join the chorus of indignantly aggressive voices. I remember anchoring a show from Jantar Mantar surrounded by Anna supporters. By the end of the programme, I was speaking a language which suggested I had become one of them! The popular Hindi news channels in particular, I suspect, were engaged in a class war—Anna, they felt, was storming the citadel of a corrupt and privileged anglicized ruling elite.

Not having experienced this kind of visible public protest, literally at the doorsteps of the state, the government, which had a communication strategy that oscillated between ambivalence and non-existence, pressed the alarm button. Ambika Soni, then information and broadcasting minister, called up to ‘suggest’ we ‘tone down’ our coverage. Unlike other information and broadcsting ministers, Soni was generally non-interfering. Not that day. ‘Don’t you have any other news to show but Anna?’ she asked pointedly.

A section of the establishment was convinced that Anna’s movement was an RSS-backed conspiracy designed to destabilize the UPA government.